

Best practice guidance for reporting AI usage

Problem statement

Release 5.1 of the COUNTER Code of Practice was developed prior to the public availability of generative and agentic artificial intelligence. In 2025 we started developing these best practice guidelines, drawing on the existing Extensions protocol outlined in Section 11 (<https://cop5.countermetrics.org/en/5.1.0.1/11-extending/index.html>), to facilitate reporting on AI usage.

These guidelines apply primarily to AI tools on publisher platforms: third-party and off-site tools like ChatGPT, Consensus or Perplexity may find the guidelines useful in conjunction with our existing [Syndicated Usage best practices](#).

Distinguishing between human, bot and agentic usage

[Section 7.8](#) of the Code of Practice states that activity that is not initiated by human users SHOULD NOT be included in COUNTER usage reports. That is, only human usage should be included, whether that's actual humans or humans running text and data mining activity (which must be tracked per [Section 7.10](#)). That rule was created before the advent of easy access to AI agents. We are aware that AI agents are not the same as the bots and crawlers that we have historically excluded from reporting. We have addressed that issue in the guidance.

Using Extensions to report on AI usage

This section of the best practice guidance sets out our recommendations for using the Extensions protocol laid out in [Section 11.4](#) of the Code of Practice to best report on AI usage. This relies on report providers using shared custom elements for reporting agentic usage.

Extension one: Access_Method

For reporting agentic usage, report providers should apply the principles of Section 11.4 by adding a reserved Access_Method: Agent.

Adding this extension is the simplest technical solution for the question of reporting on agentic usage.

Potential extension two: Metric_Type

For reporting agentic usage, report providers could apply the principles of Section 11.4 by using reserved Metric_Types: